

Ecosystems

All over the world, living things exist in distinct kinds of places called ecosystems. Each has its own climate, soil, and complex community of plants and animals. Oceans and deserts have their own ecosystems.

Natural variety

There are different ecosystems all over the world, and the animals and plants in each one are adapted to its conditions.

Homes sweet homes

One ecosystem contains a number of habitats. A habitat is the natural home of a particular plant or animal. A tree, or even a leaf, can be a habitat.

Trees offer shelter for animals, and food in the form of leaves and berries.

Forests

Wherever there is enough rain, forests grow, and they provide homes for a huge range of plants and animals.

Oceans

More than 70 per cent of the Earth's surface is covered by ocean, which contains many different habitats.

Rivers and lakes

Freshwater ecosystems exist in pools, lakes, rivers, and streams. They are found over most of the world's land surface.

Polar and tundra

The freezing polar lands are at the far north and south of Earth, in the Arctic and Antarctic. At the edges farthest away from the poles, they merge into warmer tundra areas.